ZERO SPEED FOR EXCITED RANDOM WALKS ON THE EVENT OF NON-TRANSIENCE

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ABSTRACT. An excited random walk on $\mathbb{Z}^d$ moves, on its i-th visit to a site x, according to the i-th entry of a stack of transition probabilities attached to x; the stacks are independent and identically distributed over the sites. Kosygina and Zerner asked whether $X_n/n \to 0$ almost surely on the event that $|X_n|$ does not tend to infinity, assuming only that the stacks are i.i.d. and every entry is positive. We prove that it does, in every dimension $d \geq 2$ (the case $d = 1$ is due to Amir, Berger and Orenshtein) and with no further restriction on the stacks, which may be infinite and may push in any direction. We also prove the excited-walk form of Zerner's law of large numbers for random walk in random environment: if, for a coordinate direction e, the events $X_n \cdot e \to +\infty$ and $X_n \cdot e \to -\infty$ both have probability zero, then $X_n \cdot e/n \to 0$ almost surely. Together with the directional law of large numbers of Kosygina and Zerner, this gives the almost sure convergence of X_n/n under the same two assumptions. The strong Markov property, which Zerner applies at the visits of the walk to the sites of a level, is replaced by a sum over the finitely many paths the walk can follow between its first visit to the level and its last.

1. INTRODUCTION

Let $E = \{\pm e_1, \dots, \pm e_d\}$ be the set of unit vectors of $\mathbb{Z}^d$, which we call the coordinate directions. A *cookie environment* is a family $\omega = (\omega(x, a, i))_{x \in \mathbb{Z}^d,\, a \in E,\, i \geq 1}$ with $\omega(x, a, i) \geq 0$ and $\sum_{a \in E} \omega(x, a, i) = 1$. The sequence $\omega(x, \cdot, \cdot)$ is the *stack* at x. Given ω and $y \in \mathbb{Z}^d$, the excited random walk $(X_n)_{n \geq 0}$ starts at $X_0 = y$ and moves by

$$P_{y,\omega}\big(X_{n+1} = X_n + a \,\big|\, X_0, \dots, X_n\big) = \omega\big(X_n, a, \#\{0 \leq m \leq n : X_m = X_n\}\big), \qquad a \in E, \tag{1}$$

so on its i-th visit to a site the walk uses the i-th entry of that site's stack. The environment ω is chosen at random with law $\mathbb{P}$, and $\mathbb{E}$ is expectation with respect to $\mathbb{P}$. The law $P_{y,\omega}$ of the walk in a fixed environment is called the quenched law, its average $P_y = \mathbb{E}[P_{y,\omega}]$ over the environment is called the annealed law, and E_y is expectation with respect to P_y. We use the two assumptions of the survey of Kosygina and Zerner [7]:

(IID) the stacks $\omega(x, \cdot, \cdot)$, $x \in \mathbb{Z}^d$, are independent and identically distributed under $\mathbb{P}$;
(EL) $\mathbb{P}$-almost surely, $\omega(x, a, i) > 0$ for all x, a and i.

Nothing else is assumed. There is no uniform lower bound in (EL), the entries of one stack need not be independent, and a stack may have infinitely many entries that differ from the simple random walk step. The mean step $\sum_{a \in E} a\, \omega(x, a, i)$ of an entry, its drift, may point in any direction.

For $\ell \in \mathbb{R}^d \setminus \{0\}$ let $A_\ell = \{X_n \cdot \ell \to +\infty\}$, and let

$$N = \big\{|X_n| \not\to \infty\big\}$$

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be the event that the walk does not tend to infinity, which we call non-transience. Kosygina and Zerner asked the following [7, Problem 4.7].

Problem. Assume (IID) and (EL), and let $\ell \in \mathbb{R}^d \setminus \{0\}$. Does $X_n \cdot \ell/n$ converge to 0 P_0-almost surely on N?

For random walk in an i.i.d. elliptic random environment, which is the case in which $\omega(x, a, i)$ does not depend on i, Zerner [10, Theorem 1] proved the following: if $e \in E$ and $P_0(A_e \cup A_{-e}) = 0$, then $X_n \cdot e/n \to 0$ P_0-almost surely. In dimension one, Amir, Berger and Orenshtein [1, Theorem 1.3] proved that X_n/n converges almost surely to a deterministic limit for stationary ergodic elliptic stacks on $\mathbb{Z}$, infinite stacks included; when $P_0(N) > 0$ the limit is zero, since on N the walk visits some site infinitely often. We answer the problem for $d \geq 2$; the proof does not use the dimension and gives the case $d = 1$ again.

Theorem 1.1. *Let $d \geq 1$ and assume (IID) and (EL). Then $X_n/n \to 0$ P_0-almost surely on N. If $P_0(N) > 0$, then $X_n/n \to 0$ P_0-almost surely.*

The main step is the following one-sided statement, which holds for every coordinate direction separately.

Proposition 1.2. *Assume (IID) and (EL), and let $e \in E$. If $P_0(A_e) = 0$, then $\limsup_n X_n \cdot e/n \leq 0$ P_0-almost surely.*

Applied to e and to $-e$, Proposition 1.2 gives the excited-walk form of Zerner's theorem.

Corollary 1.3. *Assume (IID) and (EL), and let $e \in E$. If $P_0(A_e \cup A_{-e}) = 0$, then $X_n \cdot e/n \to 0$ P_0-almost surely.*

When the stacks are constant in i this is [10, Theorem 1]. When $P_0(N) > 0$, the zero-one law [7, Theorem 3.16] gives $P_0(A_e \cup A_{-e}) = 0$ for every $e \in E$, and Theorem 1.1 follows; the deduction is in Section 5. With [7, Theorem 4.6], Corollary 1.3 also gives a law of large numbers under (IID) and (EL) alone, as Theorem 1 of [10] does for random walk in random environment.

Corollary 1.4. *Assume (IID) and (EL). Then X_n/n converges P_0-almost surely. For $1 \leq j \leq d$, the limit of $X_n \cdot e_j/n$ is 0 if $P_0(A_{e_j} \cup A_{-e_j}) = 0$. Otherwise it equals v_{e_j} on A_{e_j} and $-v_{-e_j}$ on A_{-e_j}, where, for ℓ with $P_0(A_\ell) > 0$, $v_\ell \in [0, 1]$ is the constant of* [7, Theorem 4.6].

Two consequences concern directions other than the coordinate ones.

Corollary 1.5. *Assume (IID) and (EL).*

(i) *For every $\ell \in \mathbb{R}^d \setminus \{0\}$, $X_n \cdot \ell/n \to 0$ P_0-almost surely on the complement of $A_\ell \cup A_{-\ell}$.*
(ii) *There are $v \in \mathbb{R}^d$ and $c \geq 0$ such that $\lim_n X_n/n \in \{v, -cv\}$ P_0-almost surely.*

Part (i) is the form of Zerner's theorem for every direction ℓ, and it contains Theorem 1.1, since N is disjoint from $A_\ell \cup A_{-\ell}$. Part (ii) is the first statement of [7, Theorem 4.8] without its assumption on a basis.

The idea of the proof. Fix $e \in E$, call $\{x : x \cdot e = m\}$ level m, let T_m be the time of the first visit of the walk to level m, and for an integer $L \geq 1$ let $h_{m,L}$ be the time from T_m to the last visit to level m before T_{m+L}. Zerner's proof has two parts. By Zerner's lemma [10, Lemma 3], a statement about a single path, if $\limsup_n X_n \cdot e/n > 0$ then there is an integer c such that, for every L, the upper density

$$\limsup_{M \to \infty} \frac{1}{M+1} \#\{0 \leq m \leq M : \ h_{m,L} \leq c\}$$

of the levels m with $h_{m,L} \le c$ is bounded below by a positive constant that does not depend on L. The second part bounds the probability that $h_{m,L} \le c$. At its last visit to level m the walk is at one of finitely many sites z, for the r-th time, with $r \le c+1$. The r-th visit to z is a stopping time, and by the strong Markov property the walk has law $P_{z,\omega}$ from then on. For levels m in one residue class modulo L, the events that the walk then reaches level $m+L$ without returning to level m are dominated by independent events, each of probability P_0 that the walk reaches level L before it returns to level 0 [10, (15)].

For an excited walk the law after the r-th visit to z is not $P_{z,\omega}$. It depends on which entries of the stacks at z, and at the other sites visited since T_m, have been used, and this is not determined by z and r. It is determined by the path of the walk from T_m to that visit. Let Π_c be the finite set of nearest-neighbour paths $p = (p_0, \dots, p_s)$ with $p_0 = 0$, $s \le c$ and $p_s \cdot e = 0$, and let ω^p be the environment obtained from ω by removing from each stack the entries used along p. Bounding by one the probability that the walk follows p after T_m, we obtain under (IID) alone, for all $m \ge 0$ and $L > c$, on $\{T_m < \infty\}$,

$$P_0\big(T_{m+L} < \infty,\ h_{m,L} \le c \,\big|\, X_0, \dots, X_{T_m}\big) \le \sum_{p \in \Pi_c} \mathbb{E}\Big[P_{p_s,\omega^p}\big(T_L < \infty,\ X_n \cdot e > 0 \text{ for } 1 \le n \le T_L\big)\Big]$$

(Lemma 3.2). The right side depends neither on m nor on the path up to time T_m. Each term decreases, as $L \to \infty$, to the expected probability that the walk in ω^p started at p_s stays strictly above level 0 and reaches every level, and under (EL) this is zero when $P_0(A_e) = 0$ (Lemma 3.1). Hence, almost surely, the upper density of the levels m with $h_{m,L} \le c$ is at most the right side, which tends to 0 as $L \to \infty$ for each c, and Zerner's lemma gives $\limsup_n X_n \cdot e/n \le 0$.

Related work. Excited random walk was introduced by Benjamini and Wilson [3], in which the first entry of every stack has a drift in direction e_1 and all later entries are simple random walk steps. Zerner [11] and Menshikov, Popov, Ramírez and Vachkovskaia [8] studied walks whose drifts point into a half-space, and Bérard and Ramírez [2] proved a central limit theorem for the Benjamini–Wilson walk; for $d \ge 2$ the walk in these models is transient under the assumptions of these papers, and $P_0(N) = 0$. The laws of large numbers of Holmes [5] and Pham [9] in high dimensions assume simple transverse steps. Theorem 4.8 of the survey [7] gives $\lim_n X_n/n \in \{v, -cv\}$ for some $v \in \mathbb{R}^d$ and $c \ge 0$ when $P_0(A_{\ell_i} \cup A_{-\ell_i}) = 1$ for every vector of a basis $\ell_1, \dots, \ell_d$ of $\mathbb{R}^d$. The assumption is there because nothing was known in a direction ℓ with $P_0(A_\ell \cup A_{-\ell}) = 0$, which is the case Problem 4.7 concerns; the survey notes that it is not needed in the corresponding result for random walk in random environment [4, Theorem 1.5]. Corollary 1.3 settles this case for the coordinate directions, and Corollary 1.5 gives the conclusion of [7, Theorem 4.8] with no assumption on a basis. In dimension one, besides [1], infinite stacks were treated by Kosygina and Peterson [6] for Markovian stacks.

A table of notation is in Appendix A.

2. Preliminaries

2.1. **Results from the survey.** We use three results stated in [7]: (R1) and (R3) under (IID) and (EL), and (R2) under (IID) and $\mathbb{E}[\omega(0, e, 1)] > 0$ for all $e \in E$, which (EL) implies. The survey proves (R1) and (R2) and sketches the proof of (R3), which follows that of Zerner and Merkl [12, Proposition 3] for random walk in random environment.

(R1) [7, Theorem 2.5] The range $\{X_n : n \ge 0\}$ is either P_0-almost surely finite or P_0-almost surely infinite.

(R2) [7, Lemma 3.18] If the range is P_0-almost surely infinite, then for every $\ell \in \mathbb{R}^d \setminus \{0\}$ and all real $u < w$, the walk almost surely does not stay in the half-space $\{x : x \cdot \ell \le w\}$ forever while visiting the slab $\{x : u \le x \cdot \ell \le w\}$ infinitely often.

(R3) [7, Theorem 3.16] For every $\ell \in \mathbb{R}^d \setminus \{0\}$, $P_0(A_\ell \cup A_{-\ell}) \in \{0, 1\}$.

Lemma 2.1. *Assume (IID) and (EL), suppose the range is P_0-almost surely infinite, and let $e \in E$. Then*

$$P_0\Big(\inf_n X_n \cdot e > -\infty,\ X_n \cdot e \not\to +\infty\Big) = 0.$$

Proof. On the event in question there are integers $a < b$ such that $X_n \cdot e \ge a$ for all n and $X_n \cdot e \le b$ for infinitely many n. For fixed $a < b$ this is the event of (R2) with $\ell = -e$, $w = -a$ and $u = -b$, which is null. Take the union over the countably many pairs (a, b). □

2.2. **Zerner's lemma.** The quantities T_m and $h_{m,L}$ of Section 1 are defined for every nearest-neighbour path $(x_n)_{n\ge0}$ in $\mathbb{Z}^d$ with $x_0 \cdot e = 0$, a direction $e \in E$ and integers $m \ge 0$, $L \ge 1$; in formulas,

$$T_m = \inf\{n \ge 0 : x_n \cdot e = m\}, \qquad I_{m,L} = \{n : T_m \le n < T_{m+L},\ x_n \cdot e = m\},$$

and $h_{m,L} = \max I_{m,L} - T_m$ when $T_{m+L} < \infty$, with the convention $h_{m,L} = \infty$ otherwise. For an integer $c \ge 0$ put

$$F_{M,L}(c) = \frac{1}{M+1} \sum_{m=0}^{M} \mathbf{1}\{h_{m,L} \le c\}.$$

Since $h_{m,L}$ does not decrease in L, $F_{M,L}(c)$ does not increase in L. The next lemma is Zerner's; it concerns a single path, and its proof in [10] uses no property of the environment.

Lemma 2.2 ([10, Lemma 3])**.** *Let $e \in E$ and let $(x_n)_{n\ge0}$ be a nearest-neighbour path in $\mathbb{Z}^d$ with $x_0 \cdot e = 0$. If $\limsup_n x_n \cdot e/n > 0$, then there is an integer $c \ge 0$ with*

$$\inf_{L\ge1} \limsup_{M\to\infty} F_{M,L}(c) > 0.$$

3. The estimate at the first visit to a level

Fix $e \in E$ and recall Π_c and ω^p from Section 1; in formulas, for $p \in \Pi_c$ let $k_p(x) = \#\{0 \le t < s : p_t = x\}$ be the number of departures from x along p, and $\omega^p(x, a, i) = \omega(x, a, i + k_p(x))$. The endpoint p_s has not been left along p after its last visit, so its next entry is not removed. For $L > c$ define

$$q_L^p(\omega) = P_{p_s,\omega^p}\big(T_L < D\big), \qquad D = \inf\{n \ge 1 : X_n \cdot e \le 0\},$$

for the walk started at p_s. On $\{T_L < D\}$ the walk leaves level 0 at its first step and stays strictly above it until it reaches level L, so q_L^p depends only on the stacks at sites x with $x \cdot e \ge 0$, even if p itself visits negative levels. As L increases, q_L^p decreases to

$$q_\infty^p(\omega) = P_{p_s,\omega^p}\Big(X_n \cdot e > 0 \text{ for all } n \ge 1 \text{ and } \sup_n X_n \cdot e = \infty\Big),$$

the probability of reaching every level without returning to level 0. Put

$$a_L(c) = \sum_{p\in\Pi_c} \mathbb{E}\big[q_L^p\big], \qquad L > c.$$

Lemma 3.1. *Assume (IID) and (EL), and suppose $P_0(A_e) = 0$. Then for every $c \ge 0$, $a_L(c) \to 0$ as $L \to \infty$.*

Proof. Fix $p \in \Pi_c$ and let $w_p(\omega) = P_{0,\omega}\big((X_0, \dots, X_s) = p\big)$, a finite product of entries of ω, which is positive $\mathbb{P}$-almost surely by (EL). After following p the walk is at p_s, and the entries it has not yet used are those of ω^p. By (1), $w_p\, q^p_\infty$ is therefore the probability under $P_{0,\omega}$ that the walk follows p and afterwards stays strictly above level 0 and reaches every level. By (R1) the range is P_0-almost surely finite or P_0-almost surely infinite. In the first case this event is P_0-null. In the second, since $X_n \cdot e \geq -c$ for all n on this event, Lemma 2.1 shows that it is contained in A_e up to a P_0-null set. In both cases $\mathbb{E}[w_p q^p_\infty] \leq P_0(A_e) = 0$, and since $w_p > 0$ almost surely, $q^p_\infty = 0$ almost surely. By dominated convergence $\mathbb{E}[q^p_L] \to 0$, and Π_c is finite. □

Let $\mathcal{F}_n = \sigma(X_0, \dots, X_n)$; for a stopping time T, $\mathcal{F}_T$ is the σ-field of events determined by the path up to time T. For $m \geq 0$, $c \geq 0$ and $L > c$ let

$$B_{m,L,c} = \{T_{m+L} < \infty,\ h_{m,L} \leq c\}.$$

Lemma 3.2. *Assume (IID). Let $m \geq 0$, $c \geq 0$ and $L > c$. Then $P_0(B_{m,L,c} \mid \mathcal{F}_{T_m}) \leq a_L(c)$ on $\{T_m < \infty\}$.*

Proof. Fix a finite path $\eta = (\eta_0, \dots, \eta_t)$ with $\eta_0 = 0$ whose first visit to level m is at step t, let $x = \eta_t$, and let $w_\eta(\omega) = P_{0,\omega}\big((X_0, \dots, X_t) = \eta\big)$. Before time t the walk leaves only sites at levels below m, so w_η is a product of entries of stacks at sites y with $y \cdot e < m$.

On $B_{m,L,c} \cap \{(X_0, \dots, X_t) = \eta\}$ let $t + s$ be the last visit to level m before T_{m+L}, so that $s = h_{m,L} \leq c$, and let $p = (X_{t+r} - x)_{0 \leq r \leq s}$; then $p \in \Pi_c$. Conversely, suppose the walk follows η, then $x + p$ for some $p \in \Pi_c$, and then reaches level $m + L$ before returning to level m. The path $x + p$ has at most $c < L$ steps and so does not reach level $m + L$. Hence $B_{m,L,c}$ occurs and $h_{m,L} = s$. These events are disjoint for different p: if p is a proper initial piece of p', a walk that follows $x + p'$ is at level m at a step after $t + s$ and before T_{m+L}.

Let ω' be the environment with the entries used by η removed, and let $(\theta_x\omega')(z, a, i) = \omega'(x + z, a, i)$. After following η and then $x + p$ the walk is at $x + p_s$, and by (1) it then reaches level $m + L$ before returning to level m with probability $q^p_L(\theta_x\omega')$. By the remark after the definition of q^p_L, $q^p_L(\theta_x\omega')$ depends only on the stacks of ω' at levels $\geq m$, and η uses no entry of these stacks, so $q^p_L(\theta_x\omega') = q^p_L(\theta_x\omega)$. The probability of following η and then $x + p$ is at most $w_\eta(\omega)$, so

$$\begin{aligned} P_{0,\omega}\big(B_{m,L,c},\ (X_0, \dots, X_t) = \eta\big) &= \sum_{p \in \Pi_c} P_{0,\omega}\big((X_0, \dots, X_t) = \eta,\ (X_{t+r} - x)_{0 \leq r \leq s} = p\big)\, q^p_L(\theta_x\omega) \\ &\leq w_\eta(\omega) \sum_{p \in \Pi_c} q^p_L(\theta_x\omega), \end{aligned}$$

where s is the number of steps of p. The factor w_η depends only on the stacks at levels $< m$ and the sum only on the stacks at levels $\geq m$, which are independent by (IID); by translation invariance $\mathbb{E}[q^p_L \circ \theta_x] = \mathbb{E}[q^p_L]$. Taking expectations, $P_0\big(B_{m,L,c},\ (X_0, \dots, X_t) = \eta\big) \leq a_L(c)\, P_0\big((X_0, \dots, X_t) = \eta\big)$. An event of $\mathcal{F}_{T_m}$ contained in $\{T_m < \infty\}$ is a disjoint union of events $\{(X_0, \dots, X_t) = \eta\}$ of this kind, and summing over them gives the claim. □

4. Proof of Proposition 1.2

Assume (IID) and (EL), let $e \in E$ and suppose $P_0(A_e) = 0$.

As in [10, (14)] we treat the levels of one residue class modulo L together. Fix $c \geq 0$, $L > c$ and a residue $r \in \{0, \dots, L - 1\}$, and put $m_k = r + kL$, $\mathcal{G}_k = \mathcal{F}_{T_{m_k}}$ and $Z_k = \mathbf{1}_{B_{m_k,L,c}}$. The event $B_{m_k,L,c}$ is determined by the path up to $T_{m_k+L} = T_{m_{k+1}}$, so Z_k is $\mathcal{G}_{k+1}$-measurable, and $Z_k - E_0[Z_k \mid \mathcal{G}_k]$ is a martingale difference sequence bounded by 1. In [10] the corresponding

events are independent; here Lemma 3.2 bounds their conditional probabilities. By the Azuma–Hoeffding inequality, for every $\varepsilon > 0$, $P_0\big(|\sum_{k<K}(Z_k - E_0[Z_k \mid \mathcal{G}_k])| > \varepsilon K\big) \le 2e^{-\varepsilon^2 K/2}$, so by the Borel–Cantelli lemma $K^{-1}\sum_{k<K}(Z_k - E_0[Z_k \mid \mathcal{G}_k]) \to 0$ P_0-almost surely. With Lemma 3.2,

$$\limsup_{K\to\infty} \frac{1}{K}\sum_{k<K} Z_k \le a_L(c) \qquad P_0\text{-a.s.}$$

If some T_{m_k} is infinite then $Z_j = 0$ for all $j \ge k$ and the bound holds trivially. Averaging over the L residues and intersecting over the countably many pairs (c, L), almost surely, for all $c \ge 0$ and $L > c$,

$$\limsup_{M\to\infty} \frac{1}{M+1}\sum_{m=0}^{M} \mathbf{1}_{B_{m,L,c}} \le a_L(c). \tag{2}$$

Suppose a path in the event of (2) has $\limsup_n X_n \cdot e/n > 0$. Since $h_{m,L} = \infty$ when $T_{m+L} = \infty$, $B_{m,L,c} = \{h_{m,L} \le c\}$, and the left side of (2) is $\limsup_M F_{M,L}(c)$. By Lemma 3.1, $\inf_{L>c}\limsup_M F_{M,L}(c) = 0$ for every c; since $F_{M,L}(c)$ does not increase in L, the infimum over all $L \ge 1$ is also zero. This contradicts Lemma 2.2. Hence $\limsup_n X_n \cdot e/n \le 0$ almost surely. □

5. Proofs of Corollaries 1.3, 1.4 and 1.5 and Theorem 1.1

Proof of Corollary 1.3. If $P_0(A_e \cup A_{-e}) = 0$, then $P_0(A_e) = P_0(A_{-e}) = 0$. Proposition 1.2, applied to e and to $-e$, gives $\limsup_n X_n \cdot e/n \le 0$ and $\liminf_n X_n \cdot e/n \ge 0$ almost surely. □

Proof of Theorem 1.1. If $P_0(N) = 0$ there is nothing to prove. Suppose $P_0(N) > 0$ and let $j \in \{1, \dots, d\}$. On $A_{e_j} \cup A_{-e_j}$ we have $|X_n| \to \infty$, so N is disjoint from it and $P_0(A_{e_j} \cup A_{-e_j}) < 1$. By (R3) this probability is 0, and Corollary 1.3 gives $X_n \cdot e_j/n \to 0$ almost surely. Hence $X_n/n \to 0$ P_0-almost surely, and in particular on N. □

Proof of Corollary 1.4. Let $1 \le j \le d$. By (R3), $P_0(A_{e_j} \cup A_{-e_j}) \in \{0, 1\}$. If it is 0, Corollary 1.3 gives $X_n \cdot e_j/n \to 0$. If it is 1, apply [7, Theorem 4.6] to each of e_j and $-e_j$ for which $A_{\pm e_j}$ has positive probability: on A_ℓ, $X_n \cdot \ell/n$ converges to a constant $v_\ell \ge 0$. Since $A_{e_j} \cup A_{-e_j}$ has probability 1, $X_n \cdot e_j/n$ converges P_0-almost surely in this case too. This holds for every j, so X_n/n converges P_0-almost surely. □

Proof of Corollary 1.5. By Corollary 1.4, X_n/n converges almost surely to a limit V. (i) Where $V \cdot \ell > 0$ we have $X_n \cdot \ell \to +\infty$, and where $V \cdot \ell < 0$ we have $X_n \cdot \ell \to -\infty$; so $V \cdot \ell = 0$ off $A_\ell \cup A_{-\ell}$.

(ii) By Corollary 1.4 each coordinate of V takes at most two values, so V takes at most 2^d values. Let $u_1 \ne u_2$ be nonzero values taken with positive probability, and suppose u_2 is not a negative multiple of u_1. Then there is ℓ with $u_1 \cdot \ell > 0$, $u_2 \cdot \ell > 0$ and $u_1 \cdot \ell \ne u_2 \cdot \ell$: if u_1, u_2 are linearly independent, prescribe the two inner products; if $u_2 = tu_1$ with $t > 0$, $t \ne 1$, take $\ell = u_1$. Both events $\{V = u_i\}$ lie in A_ℓ, where $X_n \cdot \ell/n$ converges to the single constant v_ℓ by [7, Theorem 4.6], a contradiction. So any two nonzero values are negative multiples of each other, and hence there are at most two: v alone, or v and $-cv$ with $c > 0$. In the second case $P_0(A_v) > 0$ and $P_0(A_{-v}) > 0$, so $P_0(A_v \cup A_{-v}) = 1$ by (R3). On A_v the limit of $X_n \cdot v/n$ is the constant $v_v = |v|^2 > 0$, and on A_{-v} the limit of $X_n \cdot (-v)/n$ is $c|v|^2 > 0$, so $V \ne 0$ almost surely and $V \in \{v, -cv\}$. In the first case $V \in \{v, 0\}$, which is the statement with $c = 0$; if $V = 0$ almost surely, take $v = 0$. □

Remark 5.1. The event N need not be the event that every site is visited infinitely often. For instance, in $d = 2$ give each site an independent uniformly chosen $a \in E$, and let the i-th entry of its stack put mass $1 - 3\varepsilon_i$ on a and $\varepsilon_i = 2^{-i-4}$ on each other direction. With positive probability the directions at 0 and e_1 point at each other and the walk moves back and forth between these two sites forever, since

$$\frac{1}{16}\prod_{i\geq 1}\left(1 - 3\cdot 2^{-i-4}\right)^2 > 0.$$

This environment satisfies (IID) and (EL). Its range is finite with positive probability, hence P_0-almost surely finite by (R1), and $P_0(N) = 1$.

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This work was done by multiple AI agents, Claude (Anthropic) and Codex (OpenAI), connected to Math Brain [13] and working together inside the Brain framework [15], a shared, persistent memory in which the agents record claims, proofs, failed attempts and methods, retrieve one another's results, coordinate who works on what, and audit each other's work. For more on the details behind the Brain and Math Brain, see the Math Brain paper [14], the Math Brain repository [13] and the Brain framework repository [15].

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Declaration of competing interest

The author holds equity in Heights Labs and in Convex Nexus Capital and has a management role at Convex Nexus Capital. These entities are included in the funding declaration above.

Declaration of generative AI and AI-assisted technologies

A Codex agent (OpenAI) proved Theorem 1.1; a second Codex agent checked the proof as a referee; a Claude agent (Anthropic) checked the steps and prepared the manuscript. The author directed the work and is responsible for the content of the paper and for decisions concerning its dissemination.

Code availability

Exact finite-horizon checks of the path sum in the proof of Lemma 3.2, checks of $F_{M,L}(c)$ on random paths, and a simulation of the example in Remark 5.1 are in the repository

`https://github.com/yspennstate/excited-walk-zero-speed-non-transience`.

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Appendix A. Notation

Symbol	Meaning	First appears
E	the coordinate directions, the $2d$ unit vectors of $\mathbb{Z}^d$	Section 1
$\omega(x,a,i)$	probability of step a on the i-th visit to x (an entry of the stack at x)	Section 1
X_n	the excited random walk; its range is $\{X_n : n \geq 0\}$	Section 1
$P_{y,\omega}$, P_y, $\mathbb{P}$	quenched law, annealed law, law of the environment	Section 1
(IID), (EL)	the two assumptions on $\mathbb{P}$	Section 1
$\mathbb{E}$, E_y	expectation with respect to $\mathbb{P}$ and to P_y	Section 1
A_ℓ	the event $X_n \cdot \ell \to +\infty$	Section 1
N	the event $\lvert X_n\rvert \not\to \infty$	Section 1
v_ℓ	the limit of $X_n \cdot \ell/n$ on A_ℓ	Corollary 1.4
level m	the set $\{x : x \cdot e = m\}$	Section 1
T_m, $h_{m,L}$	time of the first visit to level m; time from T_m to the last visit to level m before T_{m+L}	Section 1
Π_c	nearest-neighbour paths from 0 with at most c steps that end at level 0	Section 1
ω^p	the environment with the entries used along p removed	Section 1
$I_{m,L}$	times n with $T_m \leq n < T_{m+L}$ at which the walk is at level m	Section 2
$F_{M,L}(c)$	fraction of levels $m \leq M$ with $h_{m,L} \leq c$	Section 2
k_p	departure counts of p	Section 3
q_L^p, q_∞^p, D	probability of reaching level L before time D; its limit; the first time $n \geq 1$ with $X_n \cdot e \leq 0$	Section 3
$a_L(c)$	$\sum_{p\in\Pi_c} \mathbb{E}[q_L^p]$	Section 3
w_p	quenched probability of following p	Lemma 3.1
$\mathcal{F}_n$, $\mathcal{F}_T$	the natural filtration; the σ-field at a stopping time	Section 3
$B_{m,L,c}$	the event $T_{m+L} < \infty$, $h_{m,L} \leq c$	Section 3
η, w_η, ω', θ_x	a path up to its first visit to level m; quenched probability of following η; the environment with the entries used by η removed; the shift by x	Lemma 3.2
m_k, $\mathcal{G}_k$, Z_k	the levels $r + kL$; $\mathcal{F}_{T_{m_k}}$; the indicator of $B_{m_k,L,c}$	Section 4

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